we also had a difficult situation in the German Democratic Republic in 1953. The imperialists were instigating the fall of the workers-and-peasants' power from outside and counted on counter-revolution from within. We, therefore, had to act quickly. We combined political with administrative measures. We made a public appeal to the party members and functionaries of our party, to all who were committed to the defence and strengthening of the workers-and-peasants' state. Within a short time, we managed to isolate the counter-revolutionary forces from the workers and to defeat them.13

In the end, the meeting produced relatively little. Much to Honecker's disgust – Brezhnev led Warsaw Pact leaders to rigorously reject military intervention. But never one to be deterred, Honecker suggested to Stanislaw Kania a list of drastic measures to get workers under control. (Kania did not adopt any of his suggestions.)14

To the public, then and since, Honecker appeared in those tense months as an agitated soul, filled with alarm and anger over his unstable neighbour. A secret BND report noted that he had been taciturn and 'occasionally even bitter' since his December meeting with Brezhnev. 'Obviously,' the report noted, 'it is difficult for him to come to terms with the Kremlin's wait-and-see policy towards the still smouldering counter-revolutionary process in Poland.' His mood was also, if the BND is to be believed, affected by his personal domestic arrangements.

The agency reported that according to a 'high SED official', the union between Margot and Erich Honecker was 'still broken'. Furthermore, a source, identified as 'GZ10' reported that while outwardly Margot supported her husband out of duty, the marriage was floundering. Interestingly, the same document contains the curious line: 'Is Margot H. in a relationship with Günter Mittag?' While rumours of an affair were rife, nothing was ever confirmed.

In a relationship punctuated by humiliations, Margot lived unhappily with Erich's wandering eye and unhealthy penchant for Western porn (the VHS porn videos, paradoxically, were allegedly procured by Günter Mittag from